

INSTRUCTIONAL GUIDANCE FOR USE OF ROLE-PLAY, SIMULATIONS, AND ASSUMING DIFFERENT PERSPECTIVES

Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) acknowledges that role-play, simulations, and assuming different perspectives can be valuable learning experiences. The purpose of this regulation is to provide expectations for the use of role-play, simulations, and assuming the perspective of others during instruction. For the purpose of this guidance, role play is defined as an instructional strategy in which students take on roles and engage in real-world scenarios or events with the purpose of gaining an understanding of a complex or abstract concept. For theater classes and theatrical productions, please refer to Policy 8310 (Theatrical Presentations) and its corresponding regulation for guidance. Such instruction should otherwise follow the expectations for communications with stakeholders as set forth in Policy 5420 (Controversial and Sensitive Curriculum Standards), where applicable.

A. Instructional Guidance for Use of Role-Play, Simulations, and Assuming Different Perspectives.

1. Role-play, simulations, and assuming different perspectives can be valuable learning experiences; however, using these instructional strategies around traumatic topics can often trivialize the experience of those who actually experienced injustices and oversimplify historical events. Teachers must use caution and not use activities that can potentially cause harm to students. Teachers are responsible for creating a welcoming, inclusive, and affirming environment. The following actions must be followed to support the creation of this environment:

- a. Role-playing, simulations, and having students assume perspectives where students are asked to relive traumatic events where they could be adversely impacted shall not be used as an instructional strategy.
- b. These activities shall not include or involve circumstances in which students are role-playing or simulating enslavement, genocide, and/or the forced removal or segregation of a population.
- c. LCPS staff should not group or separate students by race, gender, religion, or sexual orientation.

2. When planning to use sensitive or controversial content for role-play or simulations, teachers will work with their collaborative learning team (CLT) or other colleagues while planning instructional practices for the classroom. Teachers are expected to follow these steps when planning on using such instructional activities in the classroom.

- a. Determine intended outcomes for students and ensure they align

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with the curriculum.

- b. Determine what people and/or events students are portraying or experiencing. If there are any direct associations to sensitive topics, including but not restricted to, the examples provided above, the lesson must not be implemented.
- c. Ensure any planned activity does not trivialize or gamify violence or systems of oppression.
- d. Ensure any simulation does not mirror a traumatic event.

3. Upon completion of an activity, staff are encouraged to provide ample time for students to debrief the experience and give students and opportunity to disengage from the role at the conclusion of the activity.

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Cross Ref: [Policy 8310](#), Theatrical Presentations; [Policy 5420](#), Controversial and Sensitive Curriculum Standards